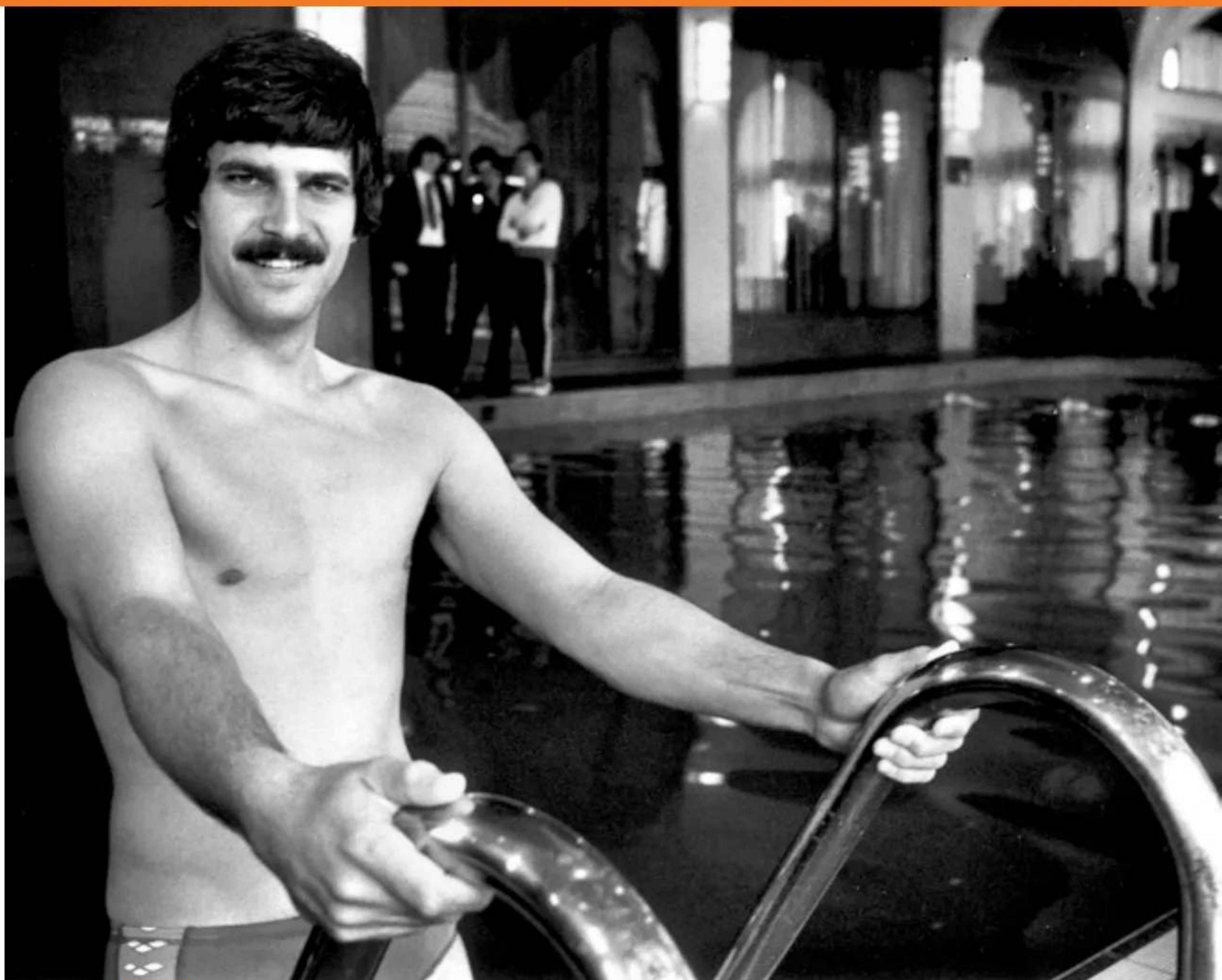




GETTY IMAGES

MARK SPITZ

Standing tall at 6 feet, 1 inch with a heavy build and a handsome face with a dripping moustache, Spitz was the quintessential macho man of the 1970s. But his claim to fame was as a stealth bomber in the pool. Munich 1972 was blemished by the Palestinian attack on the Israeli delegation and would have been buried but for the single-handed effort of Spitz, who won the maximum number of gold medals in a single Games until then – seven, each with a world record to boot — a record that would stand for 36 years. At just two, Spitz was taught the basics of swimming by his father, who

followed just one mantra — ‘swimming isn’t everything, winning is’. The early start gave Spitz an advantage, and he went on to clinch as many as 17 national age-group records when he was only 10. At 16, he gained the first of his 24 national Amateur Athletic Union titles, and with several records under his belt, Spitz was already seen as a prospective Olympic champion. All eyes were on Spitz at Mexico in 1968, but the 18-year-old could only win two golds, both in relays, besides an individual silver and a bronze. Spitz vowed he would return, which he did four years later with his superlative seven, with wins in the 100m and 200m freestyle, the butterfly events, the three relays, and the 400m and 800m freestyle and the 400m medley.